

Why is AI so accepted when it's draining our fresh water supplies?

Posted by u/jeezthatshotyall • 0 points • 15 comments

I don't know if it's a stupid question or not, so I'll ask it here.

Every dumb picture or video, every AI answer, every damn text you could have written yourself if you just tried... Are people not aware, do people just not care, or are the tech companies suppressing this information? Maybe a combination? I feel like one of few concerned about this aspect of AI usage. It's not only misinformation, news, hijacking the art, music or entertainment industry.. it's also the water usage. Will we end up only having AI but no water on this planet, then AI dies too I guess. But the tech bros don't seem to care.

"A Growing Problem. More AI means more water. In the US, an average 100-megawatt data center, which uses more power than 75,000 homes combined, also consumes about 2 million liters of water per day, according to an April report on energy and AI from the International Energy Agency (IEA).8 May 2025"

<https://www.bloomberg.com/graphics/2025-ai-impacts-data-centers-water-data/?embedded-checkout=true>

<https://www.foodandwaterwatch.org/2025/04/09/artificial-intelligence-water-climate/#:~:text=AI%20and%20its%20data%20centers,needs%20of%2015%20million%20households.>

<https://www.forbes.com/sites/cindygordon/2024/02/25/ai-is-accelerating-the-loss-of-our-scarcest-natural-resource-water/>

<https://oecd.ai/en/wonk/how-much-water-does-ai-consume>

<https://www.solveo.co/post/ais-hidden-thirst-or-how-much-water-does-artificial-intelligence-really-drink>

Comments

u/SquelchyRex • 1 points • 2025-08-16 08:29 UTC

Same reasons raising cattle for beef and leather is so widely accepted, despite that also using a lot of water.

u/jeezthatshotyall • 2 points • 2025-08-16 08:49 UTC

Yeah, I bet you're right. Normalized. Hard to see the bad aspects of something before it's visible or affects you on a personal level.

u/archpawn • 3 points • 2025-08-16 08:26 UTC

[It's overblown.](<https://oecd.ai/en/wonk/how-much-water-does-ai-consume>)

Looking at [this source](<https://oecd.ai/en/wonk/how-much-water-does-ai-consume>) you gave, it said that ChatGPT takes 30 inferences in the US to use 500 mL of water. For comparison, according to [this site](<https://watercalculator.org/water-footprint-of-food-guide/>) some of the foods with the smallest water footprint are carrots, celery, tomatoes, and turnips, taking one and a half gallons of water per ounce, or about 200 mL per gram. Beef uses orders of magnitude more water.

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Does it say how many homes that one data center can support? I bet it's a lot more than 75,000.

That said, I doubt most people are any more knowledgeable than you are. I bet most of them have vaguely heard it's bad for the environment, but also heard lots of things are bad for the environment, and don't really think it's worth doing anything about.

u/jeezthatshotyall • 0 points • 2025-08-16 08:37 UTC

Thank you for taking your time to reply, I appreciate your insight!

There are many things that contribute to the disappearance of fresh water. I don't eat beef, because of its environmental impacts, but also cus I just don't like it. Easy choice then.

Maybe it's about weighing what's more important, unnecessary usage of AI etc, or other things, such as food or medicine. Of course it's more complex than that... The world is full of grey zones.

I don't know, I might be wrong, but it seems like we're going towards a fresh water crisis if nothing is done at all.

u/Lumpy-Notice8945 • 2 points • 2025-08-16 08:16 UTC

Have you ever set these numbers in context? Compare them to how much water the internet uses and these numbers are peanuts. These articles fuel a hype around a booming industry that is AI. The whole idea that AI consumes water is flawed, computers need cooling only a fraction of these are water cooled and none of them destroy the water, they don't even make it dirty.

u/jeezthatshotyall • 0 points • 2025-08-16 08:24 UTC

So you mean that all those articles and various research are completely wrong? Could you please link me to a reliable source where the numbers are correct? I'm really interested to get the facts and I'm looking around but just find so much of the same.

u/Lumpy-Notice8945 • 2 points • 2025-08-16 08:36 UTC

Srop that dumb binary bullshit, i did not write they were completley wrong. I told you they are misleading and that you should set these numbers in context, thats not telling you they are completley wrong.

<https://towardsdatascience.com/chatgpts-energy-use-per-query-9383b8654487/>

There is a couple of calculations like these, all are vague and could be off by a factor of 10 or more.

But the bottom line is: i can generate an HD image on my gaming PC in a minute or two. The PC has a regular 800W power supply.

And i can generate real time text responses from llama3 or similar on my phones hardware.

So you now tell me how much water that's using and how that's too much.

If you want an honest calculation you need to add the training cost and calculate that into the average power usage of that AI per query depending on how much it's used. Keep in mind this is all only about electricity! Claiming to have accurate numbers for the water usage that that's supposed to cost is just stupid, yes some data centers are water cooled, but none of these articles you can even tell what's AI and what's traditional computing on these servers, they just add all of Microsoft or Nvidia together and claim that's how much AI is using in water.

u/jeezthatshotyall • 0 points • 2025-08-16 08:39 UTC

No point being rude. English is not my first language...

Ok. I'll look into it.

u/Lumpy-Notice8945 • 2 points • 2025-08-16 17:49 UTC

The point of being rude is defending myself against your accusations. You claim that i said something that i did not say and i think that's rude to do.

So to be really clear that what you accuse me of is wrong i called it bullshit and now i'm the rude one here?

u/jeezthatshotyall • 1 point • 2025-08-16 18:07 UTC

It was not an accusation, it was a genuine question, I see how that could be misread.

Then I asked for a link because I'm genuinely interested in other perspectives and facts, hence asking the question in the first place. I'm happy to be wrong if I'm proven what's right.

You seem to know more than me about the subject, thank you for the information you provided.

Rudeness is still unnecessary even if

one is defending oneself. This tactic is just sad, and an aim to try and make another person feel bad is low. Kindness will always be the higher road.

I'm not an enemy, we don't know each other.

Take care have a good one.

u/Glass_Confusion448 • 0 points • 2025-08-16 07:55 UTC

> Every dumb picture or video, every AI answer, every damn text you could have written yourself if you just tried

Your problem is that you think AI is just LLMs. You have learned almost nothing about all of the ways other types of ML and AI are integrated into every part of your daily life.

If you really mean what you posted, lead the way: Turn off your home internet and all computers, including your phone. Get rid of your car; walk or bicycle everywhere you go. Don't use modern diagnostics or medications when you get sick or injured. Don't buy any processed and packaged foods, and don't buy any foods from agricultural regions using modern irrigation or pest control.

u/jeezthatshotyall • 2 points • 2025-08-16 08:19 UTC

I thought there were no stupid questions? I don't know why you assume so much about what I do or don't do, nor do I understand why there's a need to be rude or use what-aboutisms. I don't need to tell you my contributions to a safe environment.

Maybe the problem isn't that I believe AI is only this or that, maybe there's unnecessary usage of AI. If there was a limit to it, it wouldn't use the same amount of water.

u/Front_Laugh_8595 • 4 points • 2025-08-16 08:05 UTC

Home internet has nothing to do with Ai and it using water...

A few years ago we didnt have AI at the extent we do now yet we were fine

u/Glass_Confusion448 • 0 points • 2025-08-16 21:36 UTC

> Home internet has nothing to do with Ai

Most applications are now run on cloud and edge computing by systems assisted by AI. If you're using the internet, you're using AI.

> A few years ago we didnt have AI at the extent we do now yet we were fine

And over the last 30 years people have been developing and applying ML and AI, including covid-19 vaccines, a 97% effective malaria parasite vaccine, facial recognition and object detection, several new ways to build bridges better and safer, immune therapies that identify and eliminate cancer cells better, soft robotics, optical neuromorphic processors, protein folding prediction, a new antibiotic that works against resistant bacteria, faster and more accurate diagnostics, emotional support companions that detect and respond to mood, and digital avatars that use brain implants to learn to understand and speak on behalf of paralyzed people, and life is a lot better than fine.

u/Lumpy-Notice8945 • 1 points • 2025-08-17 06:11 UTC

> Most applications are now run on cloud and edge computing by systems assisted by AI. If you're using the internet, you're using AI.

Do you even know what cloud and edge mean? Because that statement does not make any sense, edge is the opposite thing of the cloud, so you are just stating that every application either runs in the cloud or the non-cloud computer and cloud literally means a server on the internet.

And if "most" means 50+% that's just a false statement.

u/Front_Laugh_8595 • 1 points • 2025-08-16 21:50 UTC

Those vaccines weren't made using AI help though ?

u/Glass_Confusion448 • 1 points • 2025-08-17 08:51 UTC

Yes, they were. You can read the research publications in a number of journals.

u/Effective_Stand221 • 1 points • 2025-08-16 07:53 UTC

Most people are just drones who will accept anything presented to them.